Renaissance Pastimes
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Renaissance Pastimes

Compared to Twitter, there is a case for long-form invectives

IoT Mote
Oct 20

SAVE

"The tales (mostly written in verse, although some are in prose) are presented as part of a story-telling contest by a group of pilgrims as they travel together from London to Canterbury to visit the shrine of Saint Thomas Becket at Canterbury Cathedral. The prize for this contest is a free meal at the Tabard Inn at Southwark on their return."

"**Gian Francesco Poggio Bracciolini** (11 February 1380[2] – 30 October 1459), usually referred to simply as **Poggio Bracciolini**, was an Italian

scholar and an early Renaissance humanist.[3] He was responsible for rediscovering and recovering many classical Latin manuscripts, mostly decaying and forgotten in German, Swiss, and French monastic libraries. His most celebrated finds are *De rerum natura*, the only surviving work by Lucretius, *De architectura* by Vitruvius, lost orations by Cicero such as *Pro Sexto Roscio*, Quintilian's *Institutio Oratoria*, Statius' *Silvae*, and Silius Italicus's *Punica*, as well as works by several minor authors such as Frontinus' *De aquaeductu*, Ammianus Marcellinus' *Res Gestae* (*Rerum gestarum Libri XXXI*), Nonius Marcellus, Probus, Flavius Caper, and Eutyches."

Up until yesterday I had never heard of Poggio Bracciolini. A little part of my heritage seems to make a little more sense, though.

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While he is more known for his translations and tales like *Facetiae*, I was more intrigued by his sportive polemics with Lorenzo Valle, which lead to the literary genre of *Invectivae:*

"**Dispute with Valla**

In his quarrel against Lorenzo Valla—an expert at philological analysis of ancient texts, a redoubtable opponent endowed with a superior intellect, and a hot temperament fitted to protracted disputation—Poggio found his match.[7] Poggio started in February 1452 with a full-dress critique of the *Elegantiae*, Valla's major work on Latin language and style, where he supported a critical use of Latin *eruditio* going beyond pure admiration and respectful *imitatio* of the classics.

At stake was the new approach of the *humanae litterae* (profane classical

Greek and Latin literature) in relation to the *divinae litterae* (biblical exegesis of the Judeo-Christian "sacred scriptures"). Valla argued that biblical texts could be subjected to the same philological criticism as the great classics of antiquity. Poggio held that humanism and theology were separate fields of inquiry, and labeled Valla's *mordacitas* (radical criticism) as *dementia*.[8]

Poggio's series of five *Orationes in Laurentium Vallam* (re-labeled *Invectivae* by Valla) were countered, line by line, by Valla's *Antidota in Pogium* (1452−53). It is remarkable that eventually the belligerents acknowledged their talents, gained their mutual respect, and prompted by Filelfo, reconciled, and became good friends. Shepherd finely comments on Valla's advantage in the literary dispute: the power of irony and satire (making a sharp imprint on memory) versus the ploddingly heavy dissertation (that is quickly forgotten). These sportive polemics among the early Italian humanists were famous, and spawned a literary fashion in Europe which reverberated later, for instance, in Scaliger's contentions with Scioppius and Milton's with Salmasius.[*citation needed*]

Erasmus, in 1505, discovered Lorenzo Valla's *Adnotationes in Novum Testamentum* (*New Testament Notes*), which encouraged him to pursue the textual criticism of the Holy Scriptures, free of all academic entanglements that might cramp or hinder his scholarly independence—contributing to Erasmus's stature of leading Dutch Renaissance humanist.[9] In his introduction, Erasmus declared his support of Valla's thesis against the *invidia* of envious scholars such as Poggio, whom he unfairly described as "a petty clerk so uneducated that even if he were not indecent he would still not be worth reading, and so indecent that he would deserve to be rejected by good men however learned he was." (Quoted in Salvatore I. Camporeale in his essay on the Poggio–Lorenzo dispute).”

“Among contemporaries he passed for one of the most formidable polemical or gladiatorial rhetoricians; and a considerable section of his extant works is occupied by a brilliant display of his sarcastic wit and his unlimited inventiveness in "invectives". One of these, published on the strength of Poggio's old friendship with the new pontiff, Nicolas V, the dialogue *Against Hypocrites*, was actuated by a vindictive hatred at the follies and vices of ecclesiastics. This was but another instance of his lifelong obstinate denouncing of the corruption of clerical life in the 15th century. Nicholas V

then asked Poggio to deliver a philippic against Amadeus VIII, Duke of Savoy, who claimed to be the Antipope Felix V — a ferocious attack with no compunction in pouring on the Duke fantastic accusations, unrestrained abuse and the most extreme anathemas.

Invectivae ("Invectives") were a specialized literary genre used during the Italian Renaissance, tirades of exaggerated obloquy aimed at insulting and degrading an opponent beyond the bounds of any common decency. Poggio's most famous "Invectives" were those he composed in his literary quarrels, such as with George of Trebizond, Bartolomeo Facio, and Antonio Beccadelli, the author of a scandalous *Hermaphroditus*, inspired by the unfettered eroticism of Catullus and Martial. All the resources of Poggio's rich vocabulary of the most scurrilous Latin were employed to stain the character of his target; every imaginable crime was imputed to him, and the most outrageous accusations proffered, without any regard to plausibility. Poggio's quarrels against Francesco Filelfo and also Niccolo Perotti pitted him against well-known scholars."

The few mainstream outlets that I can think of that would entertain such an invective would be something like Comedy Central Roast, or Celebrities Read Mean Tweets. I think very few are cut out for receiving or sending that kind of criticism, and an unequal juxtaposition of class and influence can make public humiliation a true struggle for marginalized contenders. Furthermore, Poggio's writing in Latin potentially obscured him from the scrutiny of the vernacular speaking public, (something Erasmus also probably benefited from:

"The world had laughed at his satire, *In Praise of Folly*, but few had interfered with his activities. He believed that his work so far had commended itself to the best minds and also to the dominant powers in the religious world. Erasmus did not build a large body of supporters with his letters. He chose to write in Greek and Latin, the languages of scholars. His critiques reached an elite but small audience.[55]")

which today would fall under a squint of innumerable eyes. That said, there needs to be a place for long-form dialectic, much like that between Hegel and Marx:

“According to Beiser, "if Hegel has any methodology at all, it appears to be an anti-methodology, a method to suspend all methods." Hegel's term "dialectic" must be understood with reference to the *concept* of the object of investigation. What must be grasped is "the 'self-organization' of the subject matter, its 'inner necessity' and 'inherent movement.'" Hegel renounces all external methods such as could be "applied" to some subject matter.[89]

The dialectical character of Hegel's speculative procedure often makes his position on any given issue quite difficult to characterize. Instead of seeking to answer a question or solve a problem directly, he frequently recasts it by showing, for instance, "how the dichotomy underlying the dispute is false, and that it is therefore possible to integrate elements from both positions."[210] Speculative thought, when successful, preserves what is true from apparently opposing theories in a process that Hegel terms "sublation."

I have interlaced this compilation with excerpts from both philosophical and satirical writers, as both are are considered less dominant than other influencers with more social capital. In a future post, I will examine how role models/celebrities are idolized, and whether the relative lack of Socratic provocation is what enables their fame. In an excellent essay by Erik Hoel, he examines why society no longer produces Einsteins. My theory, is that while the educational system has improved general literacy, those who leave academia essentially become cultural consumers/producers, rather than life-long academics. While society cannot all remain in academia due to the need for governance and production of goods, the need for education as both a resource for discovering new knowledge as well as preserving ancient knowledge and history is ultimately what can help societies from escaping or re-entering their own Dark Ages.

To place invectives in the context of late medieval, early Rennaissance, Poggio’s polemics were relatively speaking, a far more milder pastime compared to promoting Crusades (although no less dangerous, depending on the pope):

“Revival of Latin and Greek

In the way of many humanists of his time, Poggio rejected the vernacular Italian and always wrote only in Latin, and translated works from Greek into that language. His letters are full of learning, charm, detail, and amusing

personal attack on his enemies and colleagues. It is also noticeable as illustrating the Latinizing tendency of an age which gave classic form to the lightest essays of the fancy.

Poggio was a fluent and copious writer in Latin, admired for his classical style inspired from Cicero, if not fully reaching the elegance of his model, but outstanding by the standards of his age. **Italy was barely emerging from what Petrarch had termed the Dark Ages, while Poggio was facing the unique challenge of making "those frequent allusions to the customs and transactions of his own times**, which render his writings so interesting... **at a period when the Latin language was just rescued from the grossest barbarism**... the writings of Poggio are truly astonishing. Rising to a degree of elegance, to be sought for in vain in the rugged Latinity of Petrarca and Coluccio Salutati..."[21] His knowledge of the ancient authors was wide, his taste encompassed all genres, and his erudition was as good as the limited libraries of the time allowed, when books were extremely rare and extraordinarily expensive.[22]"

"Poggio joined the second generation of civic humanists forming around Salutati. Resolute in glorifying *studia humanitatis* (the study of "humanities", a phrase popularized by Leonardo Bruni), learning (*studium*), literacy (*eloquentia*), and erudition (*eruditio*) as the chief concern of man, **Poggio ridiculed the folly of popes and princes, who spent their time in wars and ecclesiastical disputes instead of reviving the lost learning of antiquity.**

The literary passions of the learned Italians in the new Humanist Movement, which were to influence the future course of both Renaissance and Reformation, were epitomized in the activities and pursuits of this self-made man, who rose from the lowly position of scribe in the Roman Curia to the privileged role of apostolic secretary.

He became devoted to the revival of classical studies amid conflicts of popes and antipopes, cardinals and councils, in all of which he played an official part as first-row witness, chronicler and (often unsolicited) critic and adviser.

Thus, when his duties called him to the Council of Constance in 1414, he employed his forced leisure in exploring the libraries of Swiss and Swabian

abbeys. His great manuscript finds date to this period, 1415−1417. The treasures he brought to light at Reichenau, Weingarten, and above all St. Gall, retrieved from the dust and abandon many lost masterpieces of Latin literature, and supplied scholars and students with the texts of authors whose works had hitherto been accessible only in fragmented or mutilated copies.”

His description of Jerome of Prague, martyred for criticism rather than heresy, in many ways, hints at a sympathetic defense of the former:

“These compositions, all written in Latin − and reviving the classical form of dialogues, between himself and learned friends[19] − belonged to a genre of socratic reflections which, since Petrarch set the fashion, was highly praised by Italian men of letters and made Poggio famous throughout Italy. They exemplify his conception of *studia humanitatis* as an epitome of human knowledge and wisdom reserved only to the most learned, and the key to what the ancient philosophers called "virtue" and "the good". And thus, they are invaluable windows into the knowledge and Weltanschauung of his age − geography, history, politics, morals, social aspects — and the emergence of the new values of the "Humanist Movement". They are loaded with rich nuggets of fact embedded in subtle disquisitions, with insightful comments, brilliant illustrations, and a wide display of historical and contemporary references. Poggio was always inclined to make objective observations and clinical comparisons between various cultural mores, for instance ancient Roman practices versus modern ones, or Italians versus the English. He compared the eloquence of Jerome of Prague and his fortitude before death with ancient philosophers. The abstruse points of theology presented no interest to him, only the social impact of the Church did, mostly as an object of critique and ridicule.’

“The humanist Poggio Bracciolini, present in those days in Constance, left a direct testimony of Girolamo's trial and execution, through a letter in Latin addressed to Leonardo Bruni on the same day as he was sentenced to the stake.

‘Conducted in public and commanded to respond to each accusation, for a long time he refused to answer, stating that he would first clarify his position rather than respond to the specific accusations made by his opponents [...] But deny him this possibility, so he said below: "What iniquity is this, which for

a good 340 days I have been in a very hard prison, in a thousand ugliness, in the filth, in the stocks, in the lack of everything, while you have always listened to my accusers and detractors, and "Now do you not want to listen to me for an hour? Having given them an audience for so long, they have persuaded you that I am a heretic, an enemy of faith and a persecutor of the church. You have judged in your minds that I am a wicked man, before having could have known which man I really am. But I remind you that you are men, not gods, you are mortal, not immortal, you can spend, err, be deceived and seduced [...] '

and “Girolamo, persevering in his convictions, praised that Giovanni and confirmed that he had never heard him say anything against the state of the church of God, but against the perverse customs of the clerics, against the arrogance and pomp of the prelates, also devastators of church property.”

This morning, I thought about the how the word “gladiatorial” was used in describing Poggio’s polemics. I thought, what if there was an online website and game where users could only engage in polemics if they wrote a minimum of 500 words regarding their subject? This is also not suggesting that it be used for hate speech, but in a playful and crafty way. Users cannot copy and paste text or use repeat adjectives, nor excessive synonyms for the same word. It would encourage actual dialogue, and thinking, rather than eristic. There are “poetry slams” (Which to me sound like wrestling “body slams”) But poetry can be curt, and thus cheap. While some may have a self-inflated view of their words being economically laconic, it can often fail to appear substantive- I do not know of any famous poetry-philosophers.

Today, shows like Squid Game and earlier, Hunger Games pass as intellectual, when it signals more of a “bad fan” than a critical substitute for intellectualism. The age of maximalism arose in just a few short years as a reaction to the austerity of minimalism in the early 70s:

“Visual arts

Maximalism as a term in the plastic arts is used by art historian Robert Pincus-Witten to describe a group of artists, including future Oscar-nominated filmmaker Julian Schnabel and David Salle, associated with the turbulent beginnings of Neo-expressionism in the late 1970s. These artist were in part

"stimulated out of sheer despair with so long a diet of Reductivist Minimalism".[14]”

and has never turned back:

“Richard Toop, on the other hand, considers that musical maximalism "is to be understood at least partly as 'anti-minimalism'".[11] Kanye West's *My Beautiful Dark Twisted Fantasy* (2010) has also been described as a maximalist work.[12][13]”

Rather than accepting a claim that an artist is anti-minimalist, I set out to watch the short film Runaway, which features music from *My Beautiful Dark Twisted Fantasy.* I would consider it a work of high art. But maximalism today is widely imitated by lesser, kitsch approximations that sound more like cacophony than by a refined auteur. Maximalism also needs to content with the possibility that it has reached “peak-maximalism” and also perma-maximalism, in that it has become a fad long ago, yet it is a franchise that resembles the era of superfluous Spaghetti Western releases (some of which were not all that bad, in their originality or score). There is more art in academic research than pop culture, when the amount of content is lacking in critical storytelling.

“In the opinion of *Pitchfork*'s Ryan Dombal, *My Beautiful Dark Twisted Fantasy* is "a hedonistic exploration into a rich and famous American id".[34] Chris Martins of *Spin* says it is an alternately grandiose and eloquent production that "owed as much to the artist's self-aggrandizing ego as to the voracious id that would destroy it publicly".[49]

In a way, unfettered pop culture is the champion by the id, and academia is the championed by the super-ego. Great works of art find company in minds that like a think. Freud’s concept of sublimation is an attempt to reconcile the two into a less compulsive habit:

“it is what makes it possible for higher psychical activities, scientific, artistic or ideological, to play such an 'important' part in civilized life."[1] Wade and Travis present a similar view, stating that sublimation occurs when displacement "serves a higher cultural or socially useful purpose, as in the creation of art or inventions."[2]”

It should be said that bad art, or mediocre art is often lacking due to its lack of experimentation or deference to some sort of inspiration or influence being on the shoulders of giants. The solution, is either more of the above, or more study of the art form in general- one doesn't need to be formally trained to be considered talented, but one is aiming for wider success/appeal, they cannot be so irreverent that they only appeal to a clique of friends.

The rise of algorithmic screenwriting is definitely a challenge to aspiring artists who seek to create good movies, but nothing can replace the genuine. Audiences will always seek out live theatre, stand up comedy, and live music- a jukebox is only as good as the musicians who are featured in it.

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